PAT SUMMITT

DEFINITE DOZEN

DISCUSSION GUIDE

For Athletic Directors, Coaches & Leadership Teams



Use one principle at a time. These questions are designed to help athletic departments and teams have honest conversations about standards, accountability, communication, culture and competitive excellence.

THE 12 PRINCIPLES

1. **Respect Yourself and Others**
2. **Take Full Responsibility**
3. **Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty**
4. **Learn to be a Great Communicator**
5. **Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To**
6. **Make Hard Work Your Passion**
7. **Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart**
8. **Put the Team Before Yourself**
9. **Make Winning an Attitude**
10. **Be a Competitor**
11. **Change is a Must**
12. **Handle Success Like You Handle Failure**

Choose a principle, discuss it honestly, and leave with one observable action.

#1: Respect Yourself and Others

1. "Could I work for me?" Pat Summitt asked herself this question early in her career. If you were a coach or athlete in your program, would you want to be led by you? Why or why not?

2. What is your greatest strength as a leader? What is one area that needs improvement? Share with the group if you are comfortable.

3. Pat was known for being demanding, but demanding more only works when trust and respect are already present. Think of a time you pushed too hard. How could you have handled it differently?

4. What are three ways an athletic director or coach earns respect without relying on title, authority, or position?

5. What physical, mental, and emotional habits help you maintain self-respect and stay level when pressure rises?

6. Think about your staff or team on a scale of 1-10: how much is it "we go" versus ego? What would move the score one point higher?

7. How can you move accountability from "the boss will handle it" to healthy peer-to-peer accountability among coaches, staff, captains, or athletes?

8. Which respect-busting behavior shows up most often in your environment: gossip, hoarding information, fault-finding, tardiness, or negativity? What will you do about it?

#2: Take Full Responsibility

1. Leadership requires owning difficult outcomes, even when the circumstances were not fully in your control. Think of a team or program failure you took responsibility for. How did it feel, and how did others respond?

2. What does it mean to "own everything" in your role as an athletic director, coach, or staff leader?

3. Where have you experienced burnout by trying to own too much? What should you own personally, and what should you delegate or share?

4. What are practical ways you can model responsibility before asking coaches, staff, captains, or athletes to do the same?

5. How do you help other people embrace responsibility instead of making excuses or waiting to be rescued?

6. How would you address a chronic fault-finder who can always explain why someone else is responsible?

7. Why is it powerful to wear the responsibility when things go wrong and share the credit when things go right?

8. Leadership can feel isolating. When responsibility feels heavy, who helps you stay grounded and accountable?

#3: Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty

1. What does loyalty mean to you as a leader in athletics?

2. What are specific ways you appreciate being shown loyalty by a supervisor, coaching colleague, athlete, or staff member?

3. What does it look like to demonstrate loyalty to your coaches, athletes, school, and department - especially when things are difficult?

4. Have you ever kept someone in a role too long when their values or behavior did not match the standards of the program? What was the impact?

5. How can you encourage loyalty among members of your staff or team without creating an environment where honest disagreement is discouraged?

6. What does it mean to live loyalty before you expect it? Give an example.

7. What small acts of kindness, support, or follow-through communicate loyalty more clearly than words?

8. How does your athletic department or team recognize people who consistently put the group first?

#4: Learn to be a Great Communicator

1. Think of a coach, athletic director, teacher, or mentor who was a great communicator. What made that person effective?

2. Leaders become a barometer for the people around them. What strength or weakness in your communication tends to spread to your staff or team?

3. What are your communication blind spots? Who can tell you the truth about them, and how will you invite that feedback?

4. Timing matters. Think of a message that was delivered at the wrong time. How did timing affect the outcome?

5. Do people experience you as guarded or authentic? What makes it easier - or harder - for you to communicate with authenticity?

6. Do you tend to overuse praise or criticism? What balance would make your feedback more useful?

7. Rate your listening from 1-10. What one habit would make you a better listener this month?

8. Who in your life can say hard things to you and still be heard? What did that person do to earn that trust?

#5: Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To

1. Talent matters, but work ethic and discipline are controllable. What is one non-work example where discipline helped you achieve something difficult?

2. Look at your current staff or team. Where is self-discipline strong, and where does someone need a nudge?

3. What is an example of external discipline? What is an example of internal discipline? Which creates the healthier long-term culture?

4. How can you build an environment where people do not need to be constantly driven because they learn to drive themselves?

5. What habits allow you to model self-discipline when no one is watching?

6. What does firm, fair, and consistent discipline look like in your program? Where can inconsistency create resentment?

7. Are your expectations clear enough that coaches and athletes know what good looks like before a problem happens?

8. Think of a rule or standard that was enforced clearly and consistently. What did that clarity do for performance and trust?

#6: Make Hard Work Your Passion

1. Life on a dairy farm helped shape Pat Summitt long before the championships. What experiences in your own life taught you how to work?

2. What does it mean to make hard work your passion rather than simply tolerate it?

3. How do you define hard work personally? Does demanding work usually drain you, energize you, or depend on the purpose behind it?

4. Who modeled hard work for you? What specific behavior did you learn from that person?

5. Where have you had to work harder than the people around you? What did that season teach you?

6. Think of a time you cared so much about the mission that the hard work felt almost effortless. What made it different?

7. Who is the hardest-working leader you know in athletics? What can you borrow from that person?

8. What is one hard thing your program is avoiding right now that would become easier if everyone attacked it together?

#7: Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart

1. Hard work aimed at the wrong target is still wasted effort. What does working smart mean in your role?

2. What are you doing to continue your own education as an athletic director or coach?

3. What learning opportunities are available to your coaches, staff, or athletes that you are not fully using?

4. How do you study competitors, opponents, or peer programs without simply copying them?

5. What can you learn from the strongest people already inside your own department or team?

6. Where is your group spending a lot of energy without enough return? What could be simplified, stopped, or redesigned?

7. Athletes build muscle memory through repetition. What leadership or communication habit should your staff repeat until it becomes automatic?

8. What does success mean for your program beyond the scoreboard? How does that definition help you prioritize?

#8: Put the Team Before Yourself

1. Great teams often begin to feel like a chosen family. What could your department or team do to create stronger trust and connection?

2. What bonding experiences have mattered most to your group? Were they planned or did they happen naturally?

3. Healthy teams still have conflict. How does your group handle disagreement now, and what would better conflict look like?

4. What unspoken expectations do people have to meet to be trusted on your team? Should those expectations be made explicit?

5. Who has been an unexpected hero or pacesetter in your program? What did that person do, and how did others respond?

6. Are your people motivated more by carrots or sticks? What are the risks of relying too heavily on either?

7. Why is earned authority stronger than positional power? What helps a leader earn authority in athletics?

8. What is one decision you could make this week that puts the team ahead of your own convenience, ego, or recognition?

#9: Make Winning an Attitude

1. Does your team or department currently carry a predominant attitude of winning, surviving, or expecting things to go wrong? What creates that mindset?

2. What is the last meaningful win your group celebrated together? Did you celebrate the behavior that produced it or only the outcome?

3. Think of a painful loss or setback. How did your people respond in the next 24 hours?

4. What moment of adversity affected the whole group? What did the team attitude reveal during that time?

5. What opportunity did a past failure create that you could not see at first?

6. What can you do as a leader to make positivity credible rather than forced?

7. How can you simulate winning in practice, preparation, meetings, or daily standards before competition begins?

8. What is one daily behavior that would make winning an attitude rather than an event?

#10: Be a Competitor

1. Does competition come naturally to you, or do you have to deliberately turn it on? How ready are you to compete on an average day?

2. What emotions come to mind when you hear the word competition? Which of those emotions help you, and which can hurt you?

3. Think of a strong rival or competitor from your past. How did that person or program make you better?

4. How did you have to adjust your preparation or behavior because of strong competition?

5. Has a competitor ever indirectly helped you push through an obstacle? What did that experience teach you?

6. Who are your current competitive benchmarks - on the field, in culture, in academics, or in operations? What do they do especially well?

7. On a scale of 1-10, how competitive is your team or department as a whole? What would move it one point higher?

8. Competition reveals character. What has competition revealed about you that you needed to know?

#11: Change is a Must

1. On a scale of 1-10, how comfortable are you personally with change?

2. How comfortable are your coaches, staff, or athletes with change? Where does resistance usually show up?

3. Does your program change frequently, or only when circumstances force it? Why?

4. What major change in your department or team ultimately made you better?

5. How proactive have you been about initiating change before a crisis makes it unavoidable?

6. Think of a change that failed. Was the idea wrong, the timing wrong, the communication poor, or the follow-through incomplete?

7. How is change necessary for your own growth as a leader?

8. What change does your program need now that everyone can see but no one has fully owned yet?

#12: Handle Success Like You Handle Failure

1. Pat Summitt believed that on the road to success, you never arrive. What does that mean to you?

2. What can you learn from success that is different from what you learn from failure?

3. Think of a loss that clarified the next step for your team. What became obvious because things did not go your way?

4. Has success ever created complacency, blind spots, entitlement, or overconfidence in your group? How did you recognize it?

5. When things go well, who gets the credit? When things go badly, who gets the blame? What does that pattern reveal about your culture?

6. Which teaches you more personally - winning or losing? Why?

7. How do you celebrate success without lowering the standard for what comes next?

8. How can you create a culture where people are not afraid to fail, but are expected to learn quickly and respond?

PUT THE DEFINITE DOZEN TO WORK

Turn discussion into standards.

A simple staff-meeting rhythm for moving from principle to action.

1. **PICK**
   Choose one principle that matters right now.

2. **DISCUSS**
   Give the room 10-15 minutes to answer honestly.

3. **DECIDE**
   Name one observable behavior that must change or continue.

4. **FOLLOW UP**
   Revisit the commitment at the next meeting.

12-PRINCIPLE STAFF CHECK-IN

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Strong culture is built when standards are discussed, modeled, reinforced and revisited.